

changes in configuration files. These changes will sometimes take effect for everything you do in VS Code, while others will affect only the files within the folder that contains the configuration file.

For example, if you have a configuration file in your `python_work` folder, those settings will only affect the files in that folder (and its subfolders). This is a good feature, because it means you can have project-specific settings that override your global settings.

Using Tabs and Spaces

If you use a mix of tabs and spaces in your code, it can cause problems in your programs that are difficult to diagnose. When working in a `.py` file with the Python extension installed, VS Code is configured to insert four spaces whenever you press the TAB key. If you're writing only your own code and you have the Python extension installed, you'll likely never have an issue with tabs and spaces.

However, your installation of VS Code may not be configured correctly. Also, at some point, you may end up working on a file that has only tabs or a mix of tabs and spaces. If you suspect any issue with tabs and spaces, look at the status bar at the bottom of the VS Code window and click either **Spaces** or **Tab Size**. A drop-down menu will appear that lets you switch between using tabs and using spaces. You can also change the default indentation level and convert all indentation in the file to either tabs or spaces.

If you're looking at some code and you're not sure whether the indentation consists of tabs or spaces, highlight several lines of code. This will make the invisible whitespace characters visible. Each space will show up as a dot, and each tab will show up as an arrow.

NOTE

In programming, spaces are preferred over tabs because spaces can be interpreted unambiguously by all tools that work with a code file. The width of tabs can be interpreted differently by different tools, which leads to errors that can be extremely difficult to diagnose.

Changing the Color Theme

VS Code uses a dark theme by default. If you want to change this, click **File** (**Code** in the menu bar on macOS), then click **Preferences** and choose **Color Theme**. A drop-down list will appear, and it will let you choose a theme that works well for you.

Setting the Line Length Indicator

Most editors allow you to set up a visual cue, usually a vertical line, to show where your lines should end. In the Python community, the convention is to limit lines to 79 characters or less.

To set this feature, click **Code** and then **Preferences**, and then choose **Settings**. In the dialog that appears, enter **rulers**. You'll see a setting for